

RUBBER BRIDGE

Rubber Bridge is the classic home and club form of Contract Bridge, played by four players in two partnerships (North–South vs. East–West). Bridge combines a bidding phase — an auction to determine the contract — with a trick-taking phase where the declaring partnership attempts to fulfil the contract. A rubber is the best of three games.

SETUP

- ♦ 4 players in fixed partnerships: North–South and East–West.
- ♦ Two standard 52-card decks (alternated between deals).
- ♦ Determine the first dealer by drawing a card; high card deals. The deal rotates clockwise.

DEAL

Dealer distributes all 52 cards clockwise, one at a time, face down. Each player receives 13 cards.

CARD RANKINGS

Within each suit (high to low): A, K, Q, J, 10, 9, 8, 7, 6, 5, 4, 3, 2.

Suit ranking (for notrump and slam purposes): Spades > Hearts > Diamonds > Clubs.

High Card Points (HCP): Ace = 4, King = 3, Queen = 2, Jack = 1. A standard 52-card deck contains 40 HCP. An opening hand typically requires 12–13+ HCP.

THE AUCTION (BIDDING)

Starting with the dealer, players bid in clockwise order. A bid names a number (1–7) and a strain (Clubs, Diamonds, Hearts, Spades, or Notrump). The number represents how many tricks above 6 the partnership contracts to take (e.g., a bid of 3 Hearts contracts for 9 tricks with Hearts as trump).

Calls: Players may bid (any legal bid higher than the previous), pass, double (if the previous call was a bid by an opponent), or redouble (if the previous call was a double by an opponent).

Auction ends: Three consecutive passes end the auction. The final bid becomes the contract. If all four players pass immediately (a passed-out hand), the hand is redealt with no score.

The declarer: The first player on the contracting partnership who named the strain of the final contract becomes the declarer. The declarer's left-hand opponent leads the first trick.

THE PLAY

Dummy: After the opening lead, the declarer's partner (dummy) lays all cards face-up on the table, arranged by suit. The dummy plays no active role; the declarer calls plays from dummy's hand.

Tricks: Each trick consists of four cards, one per player, played clockwise. A player must follow suit if able; if unable, may play any card. The highest card of the led suit wins the trick unless a trump card has been played, in which case the highest trump wins. Winner of each trick leads the next.

Trump: The trump suit (if any) is named by the contract. In Notrump, there is no trump suit.

SCORING

Scoring is cumulative on a scorecard divided into "below the line" (trick points) and "above the line" (bonuses and penalties).

Trick points (below the line):

STRAIN	PER OVERTRICK (VALUE)	PER TRICK CONTRACTED
Clubs or Diamonds (minor suits)	20 per trick	20 per trick
Hearts or Spades (major suits)	30 per trick	30 per trick
Notrump	40 for first trick, 30 per subsequent	Same

Game: A partnership reaches game when their trick points below the line total 100 or more in a single game. The contract must be fulfilled to score below the line (undertricks score only penalties above the line).

Vulnerable: A partnership that has won one game in the current rubber is "vulnerable." Bonuses and penalties are higher when vulnerable.

Doubled and redoubled contracts: A doubled contract that is made scores trick points $\times 2$ (below the line). Redoubled: $\times 4$. A "Insult bonus" of 50 above the line also applies for making a doubled or redoubled contract.

Bonuses (above the line):

BONUS	AMOUNT
Small Slam (12 tricks) — not vulnerable	500
Small Slam — vulnerable	750
Grand Slam (13 tricks) — not vulnerable	1000
Grand Slam — vulnerable	1500
Rubber bonus (won 2–0)	700
Rubber bonus (won 2–1)	500
Part-score if rubber unfinished	50

Overtricks (above the line):

CONDITION	PER OVERTICK
Undoubled	Trick value (20 or 30)
Doubled, not vulnerable	100
Doubled, vulnerable	200
Redoubled, not vulnerable	200
Redoubled, vulnerable	400

Undertricks (penalties, above the line against the declaring partnership):

TRICKS SHORT	UNDOUBLED	DOUBLED NV	DOUBLED V	REDOUBLED NV	REDOUBLED V
1	50	100	200	200	400
2	100	300	500	600	1000
3	150	500	800	1000	1600
Each additional	+50	+300 NV / +300 V	same	+600	+600

RUBBER

A rubber consists of up to three games. The first partnership to win two games wins the rubber. Game points are totalled; the partnership with the higher total wins.

HONOURS (OPTIONAL)

If one player holds 4 of the 5 top honours (A, K, Q, J, 10) in the trump suit, that player's partnership scores 100 above the line. All 5 top honours in one hand: 150 above the line. In Notrump, 4 Aces in one hand: 150. Honours are scored regardless of which side wins the contract.

ATTRIBUTION

Contract Bridge. Formalized by Harold Vanderbilt, 1925–1926. Rubber Bridge scoring codified by the World Bridge Federation. Public domain rule set.